The Ohio State University

Enterprise Technology Landscape & Strategic Initiatives

April 2, 2026

1. Executive Summary & Macro Landscape

The Ohio State University (OSU) operates as a premier public land-grant institution, an R1-designated research powerhouse, and one of the largest academic and healthcare enterprises in the United States. With a massive economic footprint centered in Columbus, Ohio, the university balances a dual mandate: advancing a comprehensive, multi-campus academic mission while operating the globally recognized Wexner Medical Center. The institution is currently undergoing a period of profound strategic pivot under the leadership of newly appointed President Ravi V. Bellamkonda. Following the resignation of Walter "Ted" Carter Jr. in March 2026, Bellamkonda was elevated from his role as provost to serve as the 18th president of the university. He continues to champion the overarching vision, branded as the "Education for Citizenship 2035" strategic plan—which he played an integral role in crafting—seeking to elevate the university as the definitive national model for higher education over the next decade, focusing heavily on operational efficiency, research expansion, and digital fluency.

Enrollment momentum at the university remains exceptionally strong. The institution recently welcomed its largest incoming class in history, matriculating more than 9,500 new first-year students for the autumn semester. This demographic scale, coupled with a distributed workforce and a vast alumni network, necessitates robust, highly available technology infrastructures to support hybrid learning, digital equity, and an increasingly connected campus ecosystem. Financially, the university exhibits expansive and stable health. The consolidated Fiscal Year 2026 (FY26) budget projects $11.45 billion in total sources and $10.89 billion in total uses.[1] This capital fluidity, particularly in unrestricted funds and massive federal research grants, positions the university exceptionally well for sustained investments in advanced technology, especially in areas aligning with its core strategic pillars.

For the current fiscal and academic year, the top institutional goals are clear, aggressively funded, and heavily reliant on technology infrastructure. First and foremost is the rapid expansion of Artificial Intelligence (AI) fluency and research capacity. This is catalyzed by the launch of the AI(X) Hub, a university-wide initiative spanning 15 colleges, and a hard mandate to hire 100 new AI-focused tenure-track faculty over the next five years. Second, the university is executing a rigorous University Continuous Improvement (UCI) program designed to optimize operational efficiency, streamline digital workflows, and systematically address administrative "pain points" identified by faculty and staff. Third, the modernization of foundational IT infrastructure is a critical priority, encompassing a massive shift toward cloud-managed Wi-Fi 7 technologies, the overhaul of legacy digital storage practices, and the continuous enhancement of the Workday enterprise resource planning (ERP) environment. Finally, clinical expansion and healthcare modernization at the Wexner Medical Center, alongside continuous collegiate athletic facility upgrades, represent highly capitalized ongoing objectives that require specialized, secure, and compliant technology ecosystems.

2. Power Structure & Key Stakeholders

The technological and financial direction of The Ohio State University is governed by a highly complex matrix of central administration, distributed collegiate IT leadership, and specialized research directors. The Office of Technology and Digital Innovation (OTDI) serves as the central nervous system for enterprise IT, while entities like the Enterprise for Research, Innovation and Knowledge (ERIK) and the Wexner Medical Center maintain highly specialized, semi-autonomous technological mandates. Understanding this web of influence is critical for navigating enterprise-scale technology sales.

Name & Title	Sphere of Influence	Recent Public Stances on Technology or Strategic Vision
Ravi V. Bellamkonda, President	Executive Mandate / Ultimate Financial Authority	Elevated to President in March 2026. Continues to champion the "Education for Citizenship 2035" plan, strongly advocating for AI fluency, research expansion, and utilizing technology to elevate OSU as a national model for higher education.
Trevor Brown, Interim Executive VP & Provost	Academic Mandate / Operational Influencer	Appointed interim provost following Bellamkonda's elevation. Oversees the core academic enterprise and continues to drive the University Continuous Improvement (UCI) program to remove operational barriers.
Michael Papadakis, Senior VP & CFO	Financial Purchaser / Capital Allocator	Oversees the unified budget. Focused on advancing the university's mission through operational excellence, resource stewardship, and innovative funding solutions.

Name & Title	Sphere of Influence	Recent Public Stances on Technology or Strategic Vision
Tomislav B. Mitevski, Chair, Finance & Investment Committee	Financial Approver	Directs the committee responsible for scrutinizing and approving major financial outflows, IT operating budgets, and capital investment strategies.
Juan Jose Perez, Chair, Master Planning & Facilities	Infrastructure Approver	Oversees the physical footprint of technology, including data center expansions, smart campus infrastructure, and broad capital improvement plans.
Rob Lowden, VP & Chief Information Officer	Technical Purchaser / Strategic Visionary	Advocates for "brilliant basics," AI fluency, digital equity, and intelligent infrastructure. Brings deep experience in unifying distributed IT environments into cohesive enterprise architectures.
Rich Nagle, Chief Information Security Officer	Technical Influencer / Compliance Authority	Enforces enterprise cybersecurity posture, regulatory compliance (e.g., NIST, HIPAA, FERPA), and risk management policies across all university endpoints and networks.
Tom Bentley, CIO, Wexner Medical Center	Technical Purchaser (Clinical IT)	Manages clinical IT operations, healthcare informatics, and the electronic medical record system. Works closely with hospital leadership on strategic patient-care technology.

Name & Title	Sphere of Influence	Recent Public Stances on Technology or Strategic Vision
Richard Silveria, CFO, Wexner Medical Center	Financial Purchaser (Clinical IT)	Brings over 40 years of experience to manage financial operations, strategic planning, and capital allocations for the expansive medical center.
Ginger Breon, AVP Enterprise Support & Exec. Dir. Research Computing	Technical Purchaser / Key Influencer	Bridges enterprise IT and research computing. Manages resources for the Research Cyberinfrastructure and Advanced Computing Advisory Council (RCAC) to address gaps in compute capabilities.
Jason Haskins, Senior Director, Managed IT Services (MITS)	Technical Influencer / Operational Lead	Oversees the fiscal health and strategy of MITS, managing chargebacks and operational models. Acts as the primary advocate for IT partners subscribing to central IT services.
Ayanna Howard, Dean, College of Engineering	Academic & Research Influencer	Oversees a highly technical college heavily invested in AI, robotics, and advanced computing. Recently reappointed to a five-year term through June 2031.
Tammy Cimorell, IT Director, College of Engineering	Distributed Technical Purchaser	Represents engineering IT requirements on the IT Partnership Council (ITPC), focusing on specialized compute, storage, and networking needs for faculty and research labs.

Name & Title	Sphere of Influence	Recent Public Stances on Technology or Strategic Vision
Whitney Greicius, IT Leader, College of Medicine	Distributed Technical Purchaser	Represents the College of Medicine on the ITPC. Manages the intersection of academic medical research IT and enterprise support systems.

3. IT Governance & Service Delivery Model

Operating Model: A Managed Hybrid Ecosystem

IT service delivery at The Ohio State University operates under a sophisticated hybrid model that seeks to balance the need for enterprise-wide standardization with the highly specific, localized requirements of individual academic disciplines and medical operations. Centralized enterprise services are managed by the Office of Technology and Digital Innovation (OTDI), led by CIO Rob Lowden. OTDI provides the core backbone of the university's digital infrastructure, including enterprise applications (like Workday), cybersecurity frameworks, campus-wide networking, and broad digital learning platforms.

However, due to the immense scale and diverse needs of the institution, many colleges, research institutes, and business units maintain federated, distributed IT departments. To bridge the gap between central IT and these federated units, the university employs the Managed IT Services (MITS) program. This formalized framework allows colleges and administrative units to subscribe to OTDI-managed services—ranging from data center colocation to end-user device support—through established chargeback mechanisms and strict service level agreements. The relationship between central IT and these subscribing units is facilitated by a dedicated Relationship Management Team within OTDI.

Governance and strategic alignment across this massive environment are heavily reliant on structured, cross-functional advisory committees that integrate voices from students, faculty, and IT practitioners.

- **The IT Partnership Council (ITPC):** This council brings together senior IT leaders from distributed departments—such as the College of Engineering, College of Medicine, and the Department of Athletics—to collaborate on technology developments, align disparate systems, and solve cross-university challenges collaboratively.
- **The Research Cyberinfrastructure and Advanced Computing Advisory Council (RCAC):** Operating across three tiers, the RCAC systematically identifies gaps in high-performance computing, data storage, and secure research environments to prioritize investments that maintain the university's R1 competitiveness.

- **The Workday Support and Governance Advisory Group:** This body coordinates the continuous improvement and change management associated with the university's core ERP platform, ensuring that HR, finance, and supply chain operations remain aligned during system updates.

Operational Friction Points and Chargeback Dynamics

Procuring IT services from central authorities in a hybrid model creates inherent operational friction points, particularly regarding cost allocation, resource consumption limits, and service agility. The MITS program operates fundamentally on a full-cost recovery basis, directly billing internal customers for specific infrastructure utilization. Legacy storage chargebacks have historically been a significant source of friction between researchers and central IT. Block storage (SAN) and Isilon Network Attached Storage (NAS) are billed per gigabyte, per month directly to individual academic or departmental cost centers. This strict quota and chargeback model for data storage became a prominent point of contention, officially identified through the University Continuous Improvement (UCI) program. Faculty and researchers voiced deep concerns over rigid data storage caps that hindered their ability to conduct data-intensive research. In direct response to this feedback, OTDI is currently shifting from a strict cap-and-bill model to a more flexible "soft-limit" approach.

4. Financials & Budget Breakdown

Total Operating Budget and IT Spend Parameters

The Ohio State University operates on a standard fiscal year running from July 1 through June 30. For the FY2026 financial plan, the university projects massive, sustained economic activity, with total sources projected at $11.45 billion and overall uses at $10.89 billion.[1] The overarching budget is meticulously segmented across various fund groups, reflecting the diverse nature of university operations.

Total personnel expenses predictably consume the largest portion of the budget, accounting for $6.02 billion of the planned uses.[1] However, the "Supplies, Services & Other" category—the specific budgetary location where the vast majority of technology software licensing, hardware procurement, cloud consumption, and external IT consulting services reside—represents a massive addressable market for enterprise technology vendors, planned at $4.87 billion in total non-personnel expenses for FY26.[1]

While a single unified IT budget line is not consolidated, the FY26 plan includes explicit technology investments such as $5.4 million for the Student Information Systems Project, $332,000 for the OTDI-Workday Success Plan, and $21.3 million for Athletics Technology Modernization.[1] A significant portion of this capitalized spend is also dedicated to physical infrastructure modernization, data center improvements, AI computing cluster deployments, and major campus-wide technology refresh cycles (such as the ongoing Wi-Fi 7 deployment).

Buying Cycles and Fiscal Boundaries

The university's purchasing rhythm is heavily dictated by the strict June 30 fiscal year-end boundary. The Office of Technology and Digital Innovation, in coordination with the central Business and Finance office, issues rigid timelines for year-end procurement to ensure encumbrances and financial obligations are properly accounted for within the correct fiscal period.

Typically, by late June, a complex "roll-forward" process is initiated within the Workday financial system. During this critical window, automated purchase order creation is temporarily halted. Open obligations and requisitions that have not been fully approved and matched to invoices are systematically moved to the new fiscal year, adopting a July 1 budget date. Consequently, major IT capital expenditures, bulk hardware procurements, and strategic vendor agreements experience highly accelerated buying cycles in the late spring (April to early June). Departments scramble to utilize expiring FY budgets before the roll-forward cutoff, driving a massive end-of-year spend spike. This is immediately followed by aggressive summer deployment windows to ensure new infrastructure is operational before the autumn semester begins.

Major Funding Streams Driving Tech Modernization

The modernization of the university's technology stack is driven by robust and highly diverse external funding sources.

- **Tuition and Fees:** Generating $1.53 billion for FY26, gross tuition provides crucial unrestricted funds utilized by OTDI for core student-facing technologies, learning management systems (like CarmenCanvas), and foundational campus-wide networking upgrades.[1]
- **Grants and Contracts:** As an R1 institution, restricted and exchange grants represent a critical engine for advanced computing and research IT, providing $1.21 billion combined for the fiscal year.[1] Massive funding injections from federal agencies like the NSF, DoD, and NIH directly subsidize the procurement of high-performance computing (HPC) clusters, secure research enclaves, and expansive unstructured data storage arrays.
- **Sales and Services:** Generating a massive $6.54 billion, this stream is heavily anchored by the clinical operations of the Wexner Medical Center and OSU Physicians.[1] These highly lucrative funds are reinvested into advanced clinical IT solutions, electronic medical records (EMR) infrastructure, telehealth expansions, and high-density fan-experience technologies.
- **State Appropriations:** Totaling $558.7 million in operating appropriations and State Share of Instruction, this provides vital operational liquidity.[1] This foundational state support underpins the university's administrative infrastructure, ensuring compliance mandates and core business operations remain fully funded.

5. Strategic Initiatives & Projects (Focus on Top 3)

Initiative 1: The AI(X) Hub and AI Fluency Program

The Executive Mandate: Driven directly by the "Education for Citizenship 2035" strategic plan championed by President Bellamkonda, the university has issued a sweeping mandate that every student, beginning with the incoming class of 2029, will graduate fluent in the application of Artificial Intelligence within their respective fields. Concurrently, the university seeks to solidify its position as a dominant global leader in AI research, actively integrating AI into the daily operational fabric of the institution.

The Owning Entity: The Enterprise for Research, Innovation and Knowledge (ERIK) acts as the primary driver, in deep collaboration with the College of Engineering and OTDI. This initiative represents a massive structural commitment, highlighted by a drive to hire 100 new tenure-track faculty across foundational, applied, and responsible AI cohorts over the next five years, with the first group arriving in autumn 2026.

The Underlying IT Requirement: The newly launched AI(X) Hub requires scalable, shared high-performance computing (HPC) infrastructure and robust data/model commons. This initiative relies entirely on cutting-edge computing clusters equipped with high-density GPU accelerators. To meet this massive compute requirement, partnerships with the Ohio Supercomputer Center (OSC) are rapidly expanding, evidenced by the new "Cardinal" cluster, which integrates advanced Dell Technologies hardware, Intel Xeon processors, and NVIDIA H100 GPUs designed specifically for AI workloads.

Initiative 2: Enterprise Storage and Email Transformation

The Executive Mandate: Prompted by significant, industry-wide changes to Microsoft's licensing and pricing structures, alongside evolving cybersecurity requirements, OTDI is fundamentally overhauling digital storage environments. The overarching goal is to enforce fiscal stewardship, contain exorbitant cloud storage sprawl, and optimize operational efficiency.

The Owning Entity: The Office of Technology and Digital Innovation (OTDI), specifically guided by the Storage Strategy Working Group and the Data Storage Working Group (DSWG) operating under the RCAC.

The Underlying IT Requirement: The university is aggressively moving away from unconstrained, legacy storage practices toward a highly managed, tiered storage strategy. In late 2025, the group completed development of a new user-friendly storage finder website and soft-launched the Ohio State Storage Directory to help users navigate compliant storage options. This complex transition requires sophisticated data classification tools, unstructured data management solutions, and modernized on-premise block and file storage arrays capable of repatriating data from expensive public clouds.

Initiative 3: Campus Wi-Fi 7 Modernization

The Executive Mandate: To ensure digital equity, streamline massive network operations, and prepare the physical campus for the next generation of connected technologies, the university

is executing a comprehensive modernization of its wireless networking infrastructure.

The Owning Entity: OTDI Infrastructure and Networks, under the leadership of Associate Vice President Aaron Neal and Project Lead Ryan Holland.

The Underlying IT Requirement: This multi-year build-out, which begins heavy deployment phases in FY26, involves entirely sunsetting the legacy "osuwireless" network in favor of the "eduroam" standard, transitioning the campus to highly secure device-based authentication. The physical infrastructure overhaul requires the procurement and deployment of thousands of Wi-Fi 7 capable access points across academic and administrative buildings (excluding major public venues in this initial phase). Furthermore, it demands the integration of AI-driven, cloud-based network management tools to enable predictive maintenance and dynamically enhanced performance.

6. Procurement, Vendor Landscape, & Compliance

Procurement Vehicles and Methodologies

The Ohio State University utilizes a highly structured, heavily regulated procurement ecosystem.

- **Primary Contract Vehicles:** As a massive public institution in Ohio, OSU relies heavily on the Inter-University Council Purchasing Group (IUC-PG). This consortium provides deeply negotiated cooperative agreements for IT hardware, software, and enterprise services. The university also actively utilizes the Midwestern Higher Education Compact (MHEC) and national cooperatives like OMNIA Partners.
- **Purchasing Methods:** The university's central financial and procurement system is Workday. Faculty, staff, and distributed IT buyers utilize the integrated "Buckeye Buy" marketplace and Ariba Discovery platforms to issue RFPs and seamlessly process purchase orders. In late 2025, OTDI implemented a new Software Preapproval Process (SPP) in Workday to streamline software buying by systematically ensuring all legal, security, and accessibility standards are met before purchase.

The Vendor Battlefield

The enterprise IT environment at OSU is a fiercely contested battleground characterized by massive legacy hardware footprints and aggressive, ongoing vendor consolidation efforts.

- **Compute and HPC:** The high-performance computing landscape is heavily anchored by Dell Technologies. The Ohio Supercomputer Center (OSC) relies deeply on Dell hardware for its clusters, prominently featuring the Dell/NVIDIA-powered "Cardinal" cluster to drive the university's AI ambitions.
- **Networking:** The campus networking and Wi-Fi environment is currently a highly competitive space. As OSU moves aggressively to modernize its network with cloud-managed Wi-Fi 7, displacing incumbent legacy controllers is a primary battlefield for all major networking vendors.

- **Storage:** The university's legacy on-premise storage environment includes deep, entrenched footprints from NetApp and Dell EMC. Specifically, Isilon is widely used for Network Attached Storage (NAS), alongside traditional SAN arrays for block storage. Chargebacks for Isilon and SAN storage remain active, indicating an aging infrastructure ripe for consolidation and modernization.
- **Enterprise Applications:** Workday serves as the foundational ERP for finance, human resources, and grants reporting. Microsoft dominates the collaboration and endpoint productivity space; however, recent aggressive licensing changes have forced the university to fundamentally rethink its historical reliance on boundless Microsoft 365 storage.

Compliance and Regulatory Drivers

Technology purchases and data architectures at Ohio State are strictly governed by overlapping state, federal, and industry regulations.

- **Digital Accessibility:** A major, immediate driver shaping software and web procurement is compliance with Title II of the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), which goes into full effect on April 24, 2026. OTDI is heavily utilizing Anthology's Ally scanning tool to identify and remediate digital barriers across all CarmenCanvas learning environments for Spring 2026 and beyond.
- **Healthcare and Student Data:** The deep integration of the Wexner Medical Center necessitates rigorous, uncompromising adherence to HIPAA for all systems touching protected health information (PHI). Simultaneously, FERPA governs all student data across the academic enterprise, requiring strict access controls and identity management.
- **Research Security:** Federal grants require strict adherence to NIST 800-171 and NIST 800-53 standards for safeguarding controlled unclassified information. The university employs highly structured Technology Control Plans (TCPs) to protect sensitive research environments.
- **AI Governance:** As the AI(X) Hub expands, the university has instituted strict guidelines regarding the ethical and secure use of AI. Researchers must utilize institutional AI-approved tools tailored for public (S1) and internal (S2) data.

7. Actionable Dell Opportunities

Funded Alignment: Propelling the AI(X) Hub and Research Compute

The university's highest-profile mandate is the AI(X) Hub and the ongoing hiring of 100 new AI faculty. This initiative possesses immense, guaranteed capital backing. Dell is already positioned strongly within the Ohio Supercomputer Center (OSC) via the Dell/NVIDIA "Cardinal" cluster. Dell Account Executives must aggressively map **PowerEdge XE9680 servers and Direct Liquid Cooling (DLC) infrastructure** directly to the RCAC's High Performance Computing Working Group. As new faculty members establish their research labs across 15 different colleges over the next five years, they will require localized, AI-ready compute nodes

and edge inferencing capabilities that connect seamlessly back to the central OSC clusters. Positioning Dell's AI-Ready Enterprise architecture as the standardized, pre-approved baseline for new faculty startup packages will secure a massive, recurring hardware footprint.

Whitespace & Advisory: The Storage Strategy Working Group Intervention

A critical whitespace opportunity lies in the university's ongoing Storage and Email Transformation project. The RCAC Data Storage Working Group is actively hunting for unified, centralized long-term storage solutions to combat unstructured research data sprawl and mitigate the financial shock of Microsoft's cloud pricing changes. With the recent launch of the Ohio State Storage Directory, Dell must lead immediately with **Advisory Services and APEX Custom Solutions**. By offering a comprehensive hybrid-cloud storage assessment, Dell can demonstrate how **PowerScale** can effortlessly manage the petabytes of unstructured research data currently causing chargeback friction. Furthermore, offering APEX allows OSU to shift from a rigid CapEx storage chargeback model to an OpEx, consumption-based model.

Competitive Displacement: Rip-and-Replace of Legacy Isilon/SAN and Network Edge

OSU's published MITS fee schedules reveal a continued, heavy reliance on aging, siloed Isilon NAS and traditional SAN block storage architectures that are billed back to departments at premium rates. This legacy environment represents a prime vulnerability. Dell must execute a competitive displacement motion by pitching next-generation **PowerStore** for their high-performance block needs and modern **PowerScale** to consolidate the aging Isilon arrays. By demonstrating superior data deduplication, integrated ransomware protection via **PowerProtect**, and a significantly lower TCO compared to incumbent NetApp or aging EMC systems, Dell can dominate the upcoming data center refresh cycles dictated by the Storage Strategy Working Group. Additionally, as OTDI executes its massive Wi-Fi 7 modernization plan, Dell should leverage its strategic networking partnerships to bundle AI-driven edge security and Dell compute nodes for remote wiring closets alongside high-bandwidth network refresh proposals.